composed probably in the seventh to the fourth centuries before Christ which are accepted as scriptural authorities by most traditions, especially ***Vedanta***, claiming to represent mainstream orthodoxy. The most important texts are the *Brihad-Aranyaka*, *Chandogya*, *Taittiriya*, *Aitareya*, *Kaushitaki*, *Kena*, *Katha*, *Isha*, *Shvetashvatara*, *Mundaka*, *Prashna*, *Maitri* and *Mandukya*.

The four ***Vedas*** consist of hymns to and evocations of the *Vedic* gods. To these collections are attached texts called *Brahmanas* that comprise prescriptions for the performance of large-scale rituals by priests and their householder patrons. They also include explanations of the meanings of the ritual actions and words and explore correspondences between aspects of ritual and the cosmos. Typical statements are 'the sacrificial process represents time' and 'the sacrificial fire stands for the sun'. This style of explanation is extended in the *Upanishads* that were composed by people who had actually abandoned the performance of ritual. Their view is that the mental re-enactment of the meaning of the ritual is just as effective as its public performance. The *Vedic* deities come to be understood as personifications of aspects of human experience rather than objective realities.

The central themes of the *Upanishads* include:

Samsara: the negative evaluation of embodied human existence as belonging to a series of births confined to the physical conditions of space, time and causation. It is the sphere of mere becoming rather than true being, an endless cycle of repetitions through which one wanders aimlessly.

Karma: the notion that motivated and intentional ritual actions generate a latent potential that revisit agents in the shape future consequences and condemn them to repeated births.